

Harmonizing a song melody

Harmonizing can be as simple as adding chords to the notes of a melody. There are rules to make harmony pleasant and interesting, but, unlike math, there is no “right” answer.

Accompanying a melody

This old folksong from Croatia is a melody in two parts. It is so simple that the two parts are identical, except for the last measures (measures 4 and 8). The harmony could also be simple accordingly. The first half of each part can be identical, and then the second half can differ.

The key signature is G major or E minor.

The second half ends on the tonic, and a pleasing 4-5-1 cadence is available.

△ Rules and when to break them

George Orwell's advice to anyone writing English: “Break any of these rules rather than write something outright barbarous.”

Do's	Don'ts
Do keep the harmony as simple as you can when starting out.	Don't change the harmony on every note.
Do begin and end with a tonic chord in the root.	Don't overuse III, VI, and VII chords because they will destabilize the sense of the key.
Do keep in mind the instrument(s) you are writing for and their tessitura range.	Don't write huge leaps between chords.
Do think about what cadence (and half-cadence) you will use according to the style of your melody and harmony.	Don't worry about using simple chord combinations. 1-4-5 chords have served just fine for hundreds of years.

SEE ALSO

◀ 16–17 The piano keyboard

◀ 130–131 Chord types

◀ 136–137 Cadences

Bass

146–147 ▶

“The **trouble** with **music appreciation** in general is that people are **taught** to have **too much respect** for music; they should be taught to **love it instead.**”
Igor Stravinsky

◁ Choose another melody?

Try harmonizing for yourself, but pick a singable melody with lots of stepwise intervals and a regular structure in groups of four measures: “Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star” is a well-known example.

REAL WORLD

Joseph Haydn (1732–1809)

The greatest musicians and composers have made some of their best music from basic materials. Haydn wrote 104 symphonies that were highly sophisticated and cheerful compositions. He knew how to shape a folk melody to allow it to bear more sophisticated harmony, and when to keep things simple.

